

Objective: Transition from siloed, duplicative messaging to a unified, department-wide communication framework.

THE CHALLENGE

Working within the complexities of state government, the agency faced a common hurdle: communication "noise" caused by overlapping efforts and a lack of clear ownership. The department needed to identify systemic gaps and move toward a shared, aligned approach that worked in practice, not just on paper.

THE APPROACH: A 3-HOUR "ALIGNMENT LAB"

Rather than a passive lecture, I designed a high-intensity, 3-hour collaborative retreat for key staff members. The session was built on the principle of "Candor over Polish" focusing on how communications actually function within the daily workflow.

PHASE 1: SYSTEMIC DIAGNOSTICS

- **Icebreaker: Superpowers & Friction:** Participants identified personal "comm superpowers" and shared specific examples of departmental communication that either succeeded or caused confusion.
- **Current State Mapping:** A silent brainstorming and wall-mapping exercise to visualize the entire ecosystem, categorizing internal, external, urgent, and routine communications.
- **Pain Point Identification:** Small groups diagnosed the "why" behind delays, silos, and messaging ownership confusion.

PHASE 2: FUTURE-STATE VISIONING

We used guided visualization to define what success looked like one year from the retreat. We moved past "how it looks" to "how it feels" for both the staff and the public, ensuring the human impact of the agency's work remained central.

PHASE 3: THE DESIGN LAB

Participants rotated through three "stations" to build the actual architecture of the new system:

1. **Roles & Ownership:** Defining who leads messaging (department-wide and division-wide) and what requires central approval.
2. **Processes:** Creating workflows to coordinate announcements and handle urgent news without duplication.
3. **Tools:** Identifying the specific templates, shared calendars, and social workflows needed to sustain the system.

THE OUTCOME: A 30-DAY ACTION PLAN

The retreat didn't end with "ideas"; it ended with commitments. The group synthesized their work into a realistic framework including:

1. **Immediate Changes:** Establishing monthly cross-division check-ins and prioritizing process mapping with a focus on continuous improvement.
2. **Development Needs:** A roadmap for creating standardized templates and a clear point-person system.
3. **Accountability:** Every participant is committing to taking action, prioritized via dot voting to ensure the most critical tasks were tackled first.

KEY TAKEAWAY

By focusing on "Systems over Blame," we transformed a complex organizational challenge into a simple, actionable alignment plan that empowered staff to communicate with clarity and purpose.